

Native × Japan

Natural Personal Care Market Entry Strategy: Japan

“Clean. Simple. Effective.” - Introducing Native's personal care line to Japan's premium-natural market gap via P&G K.K.'s established infrastructure.

This report outlines a comprehensive foreign market entry strategy specifically regarding how to bring **Native's deodorant line**, and ultimately the personal care line, to **Japan**. The country of Japan is home to the world's third largest beauty and personal care market. Japan's beauty and personal care segment was said to be valued at \$32.97 billion in 2025 with a compounding annual growth rate of 3.29% according to Mordor Intelligence. The market offers a clear competitive gap, as there is currently no major domestic brand occupying the premium-natural, aluminum free, and affordable positioning that Native has established in the United States. This report takes a deep dive into Japan's cultural, economic and regulatory environments and recommends a phased entry leveraging the subsidiary infrastructure of Procter & Gamble's Kabushiki Kaisha (P&G K.K.).

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PRODUCT

Native Deodorant and Personal Care (P&G)

TARGET MARKET

Japan (Foreign Country Entry)

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Section 1

Introduction

1.1 Why Native?

Founded in 2015 by the Harvard Law graduate Moiz Ali, Native is a personal care brand created with a goal to produce natural alternatives to the standard options after Ali could not recognize the synthetic ingredients on his own deodorant label. Native first launched its classic, aluminum, free, carbon free deodorant at \$12 a stick. From there, Native rapidly scaled through a direct consumer model. Leading to \$30 million in annualized revenue and \$1 million in monthly net profits putting it in a very strong position before its **acquisition in 2017 by Procter & Gamble(P&G) for \$100 million**. At the time of its sale, Native was led by an administration of just eight employees with approximately \$500,000 raised from venture capital funding. The lean operation and high yields made it one of the most capital efficient sales in the consumer goods industry.

Following its purchase, P&G expanded Native's limited DTC product line into a full personal care brand with products ranging from their classic deodorant all the way to toothpaste and more. The brand was distributed at multiple major retailers, including Target, Walmart, CVS, Kroger, Walgreens, and Whole Foods. By 2021, Native had managed to post 46.8% year over year sales growth and was recognized as Target's third bestselling deodorant. Later in 2024, P&G publicly and internally recognized Native with their highest distinction of internal awards after **growing sales nearly ten times in five years**, the implying annual revenue of up to \$300 million. The brand's value proposition is extremely clear and increasingly sought after, which is recognizable ingredients, with all products being aluminum free, sulfate free, vegan, and cruelty free.

\$100M

P&G acquisition (2017)
with 8 employees,
\$500K raised

10x

Sales growth in 5 years
post-acquisition

46.8%

Year-over-year sales
growth (2021)

\$250–300M

Estimated annual revenue
(2024)

1.2 Why Japan?

Japan is home to the world's third-largest beauty and personal care market which was valued at approximately **\$32 billion in 2024** according to the Renub Research. Despite its scale, the Japanese market contains a clear competitive gap: no domestic comprehensive personal care brand occupies a mainstream, aluminum-free natural deodorant positioning comparable to what Native has done in the United States. The three current dominant players include Kao Corporation, Lion Corporation, and FineToday. These entities compete primarily on science-based, conventional formulations. While Kao has explored clean beauty through its sub-brand Athletia, it remains a limited experiment rather than a full portfolio commitment, and none of these three companies have brought a mainstream aluminum-free deodorant line to the Japanese mass market. The premium-natural quadrant of Japan's deodorant category remains structurally unoccupied at scale.

Like much of the world, the Japanese market is also experiencing a major consumer shift toward natural and organic ingredients which provides an efficient opportunity to meet demand and secure market share. The beauty and personal care market was valued at approximately \$32.97 billion in 2025 and is projected to reach \$38.76 billion by 2030, with a CAGR of 3.29%. More significantly for Native, Japan's natural and organic cosmetics segment is growing at a 6.10% CAGR. Which is nearly double the rate of the overall market, expanding from roughly \$1.33 billion in 2023 toward a projected \$2.26 billion by 2032 as shown in Credence Research. This is a pace Mordor Intelligence similarly flags by noting that organic formulations within the broader beauty market are the fastest-growing sub-segment, with an expected 4.50% CAGR through 2030. Consumer ingredient scrutiny is also relatively high with over 40% of Japanese consumers say they prioritize natural ingredients when purchasing beauty products.

Culturally, Japan promotes the social concept of *kirei* (きれい) which is one word meaning both “clean” and “beautiful” and alludes to the idea that one cannot be “truly beautiful” if they are not “clean.” This creates the opportunity for deep philosophical alignment with Native's positioning. Younger Japanese consumers are reported to be more receptive to imported Western brands, as well as influenced by social media discovery. As aforementioned, Proctor & Gamble already operate in Japan through P&G K.K. This would provide market knowledge, distribution relationships, and more competitive advantages that would significantly lower Native's potential market entry cost and timeline.

Core thesis: There is a premium-natural quadrant to be occupied in Japan's personal care market. Native, with P&G K.K.'s existing infrastructure in the nation, can enter this market for

Japan if the entry considers the country's regulations, culture, and consumer trust with the brand.

Section 2

Market Analysis

2.1 Uncontrollable Factors and Environment

Cultural Environment

Japan's culture reflects and is tied closely to cleanliness, a respect that is among the most institutionalized across a nation in the world. The dual meaning of the word "kirei" relates to the concepts of both cleanliness and beauty, concepts that are correlated with Shinto spirituality, public bathhouses of the Edo period, and school-level hygiene inspections performed today. Moreover, 95% of the individuals in Japan reportedly perform regular handwashing after utilizing restrooms in their homes, schools, or communities, and the practice of bathing is performed daily by the majority of residents as a cultural norm. Thus, Japan's culture of cleanliness is one that provides a beneficial foundation for the growth of a company such as Native whose products are based upon the concept of using easily recognizable, clean ingredients.

However, the genetic makeup of 80–95% of East Asian ethnicities and 80%–90% of their population has naturally reduced bodily odors due to a specific gene variant known as **ABCC11**. As a result of this alongside other factors, only 55% of Japanese use deodorant regularly compared to 92% of Americans and Europeans. Therefore, any attempt at entering this market will require additional thought regarding the value proposition of the deodorant brand, shifting it away from odor control to one of freshness and skin health. These will be perceived as values that align with the kirei culture of Japan. Portraying Native's products as an enabler or support to civic duty.

Additionally, the concept of sumehara, or scent harassment, is common in Japan, and strong fragrances are generally recognized as socially inappropriate. Seeing as they would go against the scent culture of Japan, Native's strong scents (like Pumpkin Spice Latte and Dunkin') would need to be adapted to Japan-appropriate scents such like yuzu, hinoki cypress, green tea, and sakura. Additionally, Japan is home to a large portion of foreign brands in its cosmetics market. Companies such as L'Oréal, and Estée Lauder maintain a significant foothold in Japan, indicating that imported and foreign brands can succeed in Japan – but only if they incorporate elements of the culture into their products.

Economic Environment

Japan's economy is the fourth largest in the world with a per capita GDP of approximately \$32,000. Japanese citizens spend an estimated \$409 per capita, annually, on beauty and personal care products which is amongst the highest in the world. The total size of the premium beauty products industry in Japan hit \$11.94 billion in 2024 and is growing at a 1.7% CAGR. Furthermore, the total size of Japan’s personal care products market is forecast to grow from the current range of \$32–35 billion in 2024, to reach \$38.76 billion by 2030. Japan’s aging and health-conscious population(s) is growing in number amongst its inhabitants, which is propelling the growth of the personal care products industry in the nation. However, the weak yen and the resulting inflation of imported goods in Japan could pose challenges for a U.S. personal care brand attempting to enter the market.

Legal and Regulatory Environment

Japan’s regulatory system poses the single most significant barrier to market entry for Native. Under **Japan’s Pharmaceuticals and Medical Devices Act (PMD Act)**, deodorants fall into the category of quasi-drugs. Quasi-drugs sit between thee cosmetic and pharmaceutical categories and require individual product approval from Japan’s Ministry of Health, Labor and Welfare (MHLW). Unlike cosmetics, which only require notification to the Ministry, quasi-drug manufacturers must hold an Accreditation of Foreign Quasi-drug Manufacturer and appoint a Japanese Marketing Authorization Holder (MAH) for their product with the Ministry. The PMDA takes a minimum of 6–8 months to review a quasi-drug application, though the total length of time to reach the market for an approved product will take between 12 and 18 months from the date of application initiation.

Competitive Environment

The Japanese market is currently dominated by three different domestic corporations: Kao Corporation, Lion Corporation, and FineToday. However, none of these companies feature any mainstream brands that focus upon offering aluminum-free deodorants.

COMPANY	KEY BRANDS	NATURAL/CLEAN GAP?
Kao Corporation	Bioré U, Essential, Merit, Bioré Z	GAP Minimal; core identity is science-based
Lion Corporation	Ban (deodorant), Hadakara, Clinica	GAP No natural or organic products

COMPANY	KEY BRANDS	NATURAL/CLEAN GAP?
FineToday	TSUBAKI, Fino, SENKA, Ag DEO24	PARTIAL Camellia oil; no clean certification
I-ne (BOTANIST)	BOTANIST hair care	Closest competitor in hair only; no deodorant
Abe Shoten (Deonatulle)	Deonatulle deodorant	Natural alum-stone; lacks brand scale and breadth
Native (P&G K.K.)	Full personal care system	First mover advantage

Technological Environment

Japan has an 88.2% internet penetration rate with 109 million users. According to reports, e-commerce has taken over as the fastest-growing sales channel in the beauty and personal care industry, with online sales contributing to 43.4% of the total revenue for the entire Beauty and Personal Care market. The three primary e-commerce platforms of Japan are Amazon Japan, Rakuten Ichiba, and @cosme Shopping. Furthermore, social media channels have significantly influenced the sales of beauty and personal care products. @cosme, the most prominent social media channel for beauty product reviews in the nation and with 66.5 thousand reviews and 5 million downloads of their app on the app store, maintains a unique position of trust and ultimately can heavily influence the popularity of the products on the shelves of retail beauty brands. Winning the Best Cosmetics Award on this website will result in the product gaining popularity among the masses and retail brands making it available on their shelves.

2.2 Form of Market Entry

Given the regulatory environment of the deodorant category, the ownership of Native by P&G, and the preferences of Japan's retail industry for direct relationships with well-established brands, the best approach for entry into the Japanese market will be to implement a phased approach to directly exporting products to Japan.

PHASE 1 Months 1–12	PHASE 2 Months 6–18	PHASE 3 Month 18+
Launch body wash and shampoo/conditioner (cosmetics classification) via Amazon Japan and Rakuten	Initiate quasi-drug MHLW/PMDA approval for locally adapted deodorant (spray or roll-on). Engage regulatory affairs	Deodorant launch post-approval in spray and roll-on formats. Expand to mass drugstore chains (Welcia, Matsumoto)

Ichiba. Build @cosme brand page. Initiate quasi-drug approval for deodorant. P&G K.K. acts as importer and MAH for cosmetics.

specialist. Expand to lifestyle retail: Loft, Plaza, @cosme STORE. Launch Japan-exclusive scent lineup.

Kiyoshi, Tsuruha) via P&G K.K. buyer relationships. Summer freshness campaign launch.

This entry mode is preferable to both joint ventures and licensing arrangements. P&G already owns its subsidiary, and thus there is no need for a partner. Furthermore, P&G already has the regulatory relationships and agreements necessary to distribute its products to drugstores in Japan. This indicates that the decision of the entry mode for the Native brand was really more of an internal decision of how to manage the brand within the existing subsidiary of P&G.

2.3 Expected Market Size

The total addressable market for Native in Japan encompasses three product categories. The first being the **deodorant market** which is projected to reach \$609.71 million in 2026. The natural and organic segment of the deodorant market is in its earlier stages but growing in size. The **hair care market** in Japan reached \$5.15 billion in 2025 with a growth rate of 4.16% while the natural and organic segment of the hair care market is growing at a rate of 5.96% per year. Finally, the **bath and shower product market** is projected to exceed 2.6 billion by 2030. These three markets represent the total addressable market of Japan at value at **approximately \$8.3 billion**. The natural and organic cosmetics category of Japan is specifically valued at \$1.3 billion and is growing at a rate of 6.1% per year and is projected to reach \$2.26 billion in 2032.

A modest serviceable addressable market estimate for Native in Japan would be focused on the premium tier of the natural personal care goods market in the top five urban areas of Japan. Using the growth rate of natural personal care goods in these markets of **1 to 2%** over three years, the revenue that can be generated from Japan for Native is projected to be between **\$13 and \$26 million** in year three of the brand's launch. This can grow to between \$40 and \$60 million by year five when distributions mature and brand equity is built.

Section 3

Marketing Strategy

3.1 Market Segmentation

BASIS	KEY SEGMENTS
Geographic	Urban core (Tokyo, Osaka, Nagoya) vs. suburban/rural; international travelers and expats as early adopters
Demographic	Age 18–35 (Gen Z + Millennials); working women; household income ¥6M+; university-educated
Psychographic	Health-conscious “clean beauty” adopters; ingredient-literate; environmentally aware; status-conscious premium shoppers; early adopters of Western beauty trends
Behavioral	Brand switchers dissatisfied with synthetic formulas; @cosme users; social media-influenced buyers; daily bathing/grooming routine maintainers
Mediagraphic	Instagram daily (80% of beauty shoppers); TikTok engagers; LINE messaging users; @cosme community participants; YouTube beauty tutorial viewers

3.2 Target Segment: Justified Profile

The **primary target segment** for Native consists of Japanese women between the ages of 22 and 35, who live in one of Japan’s major cities (Tokyo, Osaka or Nagoya) and who earn at least ¥6 million per year. These consumers are generally well-educated about personal care products and ingredients, and tend to be skeptical of synthetics within personal care products. Furthermore, they are heavy users of social media platforms like Instagram and @cosme to discover new beauty products and brands. These consumers are also willing to pay the higher prices for skincare and personal care products that reflect their personal values – evidenced by the growing number of domestic skincare brands focusing on natural ingredients, such as BOTANIST or The Public Organic, or the growing sales of imported skincare products from countries like Korea or Europe.

These target consumers are referred to as “health-beauty” consumers in Japan. These consumers associate their personal care routines with their lifestyles, self-care, and wellness. Thus, the brand’s deodorant product must be re-framed for these consumers to associate it with their concept of wellness.

A **secondary target segment** for Native consists of Japanese men between the ages of 20 and 30. While a few brands such as Mandom's Gatsby hold a relatively strong market share of this demographic's deodorant market, there is no natural skincare line offered by the company. Native's plans to release a full line of personal care products for men will help to fill this gap within the market.

This target market has been selected for Native for three main reasons: they are willing to pay the higher prices for skincare and personal care products, they are the most active users of social media platforms that could help to spread the word of brand and its new products, and they are the most receptive to foreign skincare brands.

3.3 Positioning

Native's positioning in Japan:

"The all-natural personal care brand from America that's as effective as it is pure. Curated for those who value what you put on your body just as much as what you put in it."

Perceptually, Native is positioned in the **premium-natural quadrant** of a map of the skincare market which is an area that is unoccupied by any of the major competitors. Competitors like Kao, Lion, and FineToday are present in the conventional-mass to conventional-premium quadrant of the map while BOTANIST and Ichikami are represented in the natural-mass quadrant.

However, such positioning must be localized to Japan. The discussion of "clean" ingredients should be translated into Japanese cultural language that frames the aluminum and paraben free feature as an intentional and positive choice aligned with *kirei* values. Furthermore, the brand's packaging should be locally adapted to include both Japanese ingredient lists and a potentially localized packaging design that reflects the premium nature of the brand to Japanese consumers while maintaining the original distinct branding.

3.4 The 4 Ps: Marketing Mix

Product

Native should enter Japan with a curated initial lineup prioritizing categories with the fastest regulatory pathway and highest consumer profile fit:

PRODUCT	PHASE	FORMAT & SCENTS	NOTES
Body Wash (300ml)	PHASE 1	Fragrance-free · Yuzu · Hinoki	Lightweight, quick-rinse; cosmetics classification — no pre-approval
Shampoo & Conditioner (300ml)	PHASE 1	Sulfate-free · Silicone-free	Coconut-derived cleansers; targets BOTANIST switchers
Deodorant Spray + Roll-on	PHASE 3	Fragrance-free · Green tea	Post-regulatory approval

All products should carry full Japanese ingredient lists, clean-beauty certification marks where obtainable, and packaging copy communicating “Clean. Simple. Effective.” in Japanese. Bar soap and body lotion can be introduced in Phase 2 as brand equity builds.

Price

PRODUCT	RECOMMENDED PRICE	DOMESTIC BENCHMARK	POSITIONING TIER
Body Wash (300ml)	¥1,500–1,800	Kao Bioré: ¥600–900	Premium imported
Shampoo (300ml)	¥1,800–2,200	BOTANIST: ¥1,200–1,500	Premium natural
Conditioner (300ml)	¥1,800–2,200	Fino: ¥900–1,200	Premium natural
Deodorant Spray	¥1,200–1,600	Ban: ¥700–1,000	Premium natural

Introductory pricing on e-commerce launch (¥200–300 discount on first purchase) could drive trial without permanently anchoring the brand at a lower tier.

Place

Distribution follows a phased approach: **Phase 1** — Amazon Japan, Rakuten Ichiba, and @cosme Shopping (Months 1–12); **Phase 2** — Loft, Plaza, and @cosme STORE lifestyle retail (Month 12+); **Phase 3** — Mass drugstore expansion to Welcia, Matsumoto Kiyoshi, and Tsuruha via P&G K.K. buyer relationships (Month 24+). Supply chain will be managed through P&G K.K.'s existing import and warehousing infrastructure, with products manufactured in the U.S. and shipped in bulk to Japan.

Promotion

Native's promotional strategy must be built around digital channels and organic earned media, consistent with how Japanese consumers discover and validate personal care products:

- **@cosme strategy:** Dedicated brand page, full ingredient transparency, influencer seeding for authentic reviews. Best Cosmetics Award nomination within two years is a concrete goal.
- **Influencer marketing:** 10–15 mid-tier Japanese beauty influencers (50K–500K followers) on Instagram and TikTok. Focus on ingredient education content — “what’s in your deodorant?” format.
- **Seasonal campaigns:** Japan’s humid summer creates a natural deodorant demand spike. A summer freshness campaign positioning Native as skin-gentle and non-sticky for commuters.
- **LINE messaging:** LINE official account for customer engagement, promotional coupons, and re-purchase reminders which is Japan’s dominant CRM channel for consumer brands.
- **PR and earned media:** Pitch Native’s founding story to Vogue Japan, ELLE Japan, and @cosme partner program with the ingredient-conscious narrative aligned with cultural and societal norms that differentiates it from generic “imported Western brand” positioning.

Section 4

Challenges and Recommendations

Native's entry into the Japan market faces a series of challenges that can be overcome through careful planning and strategy. The following table presents the challenges that the company will face in Japan and the strategies that the company can employ to overcome each of these challenges:

CHALLENGE	RISK LEVEL	STRATEGY TO OVERCOME
Low deodorant adoption due to ABCC11 gene prevalence (~80–95% of population)	MEDIUM	Reframe deodorant as skin-wellness and freshness ritual, not odor control. Target growing segment of younger consumers adopting year-round deodorant use.
Quasi-drug regulatory classification for deodorant (12–18 month approval timeline)	HIGH	Launch body wash and shampoo first (cosmetics classification). Begin quasi-drug application immediately. Leverage P&G K.K.'s existing MHLW relationships.
Deep brand loyalty to domestic incumbents (Kao, Lion, FineToday)	MEDIUM	Build credibility through @cosme reviews before retail launch. Partner with dermatologists and beauty editors for third-party endorsement.
Product format mismatch (stick deodorant vs. Japanese preference for spray/roll-on)	MEDIUM	Develop spray and roll-on formats specifically for Japan. Do not launch stick as the primary SKU. Aerosol commands a large segment of Japan's deodorant market share.
Scent profile misalignment (sumehara culture; bold U.S. scents inappropriate)	MEDIUM	Develop Japan-exclusive scent lineup (yuzu, hinoki, green tea, sakura, fragrance-free). Retire bold U.S. scents (Pumpkin Spice, Dunkin' collaboration) in Japan.
Currency/import cost pressure on pricing competitiveness	LOW-MED	Premium positioning absorbs import costs. Monitor yen/dollar rate. Consider Japan-specific smaller pack sizes at accessible price points.
Building distribution from zero in a relationship-driven retail market	MEDIUM	Utilize P&G K.K.'s existing buyer relationships with drugstore chains and specialty retailers. Prioritize e-commerce first to generate sell-through data.

CHALLENGE	RISK LEVEL	STRATEGY TO OVERCOME
Domestic natural competitors (BOTANIST, Ichikami) in hair care	MEDIUM	Differentiate on premium imported origin, P&G-backed ingredient science, and full-body natural care ecosystem. BOTANIST competes on hair care only.

Overarching recommendation: Consider this investment into the brand with the potential for growth in the future rather than with the potential for rapid revenue. The regulatory issues, trust issues with the Japanese consumers, and the need to adapt to the tastes of the Japanese consumers all suggest that the brand should expect some degree of patience in its efforts to gain the trust of those domestic consumers.

P&G's existing infrastructure in Japan will be the major factor that will enable the entry of Native into the Japanese market. Without this infrastructure and the resources that go with it, the costs associated with establishing the brand in Japan would be prohibitive. However, with this infrastructure in place, the entry of Native into Japan is simply a matter of P&G prioritizing its resources to allocate to the efforts of the expanding brand.

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Appendices

APPENDIX A

Japan Personal Care Market Size Summary

SEGMENT	2024 VALUE (USD)	CAGR	FORECAST YEAR
Total Beauty & Personal Care	\$32–35 billion	3.0–4.3%	2030–2033
Hair Care	\$5.15 billion (2025)	4.21%	2030
Bath & Shower Products	~\$660M (projected 2029)	N/A	2029
Deodorant	\$590 million	~3%	2028
Natural & Organic Cosmetics	\$1.33 billion (2023)	6.10%	2032
Premium Beauty	\$11.94 billion	4.34%	2030

APPENDIX B

Competitive Landscape Summary

BRAND	COMPANY	CATEGORY	POSITIONING	NATURAL GAP?
Bioré U/Z	Kao	Body wash, Deodorant	Science/functional	YES (DEO)
Essential / Merit	Kao	Hair care	Science/functional	Partial
Ban	Lion	Deodorant	Conventional efficacy	YES
TSUBAKI / Fino	FineToday	Hair care	Natural-inspired (camellia)	Partial
Ag DEO24	FineToday	Deodorant	High-performance conventional	YES
BOTANIST	I-ne	Hair care	Natural/plant-based	Hair only; no deo
Ichikami	Kracie	Hair care	Botanical / silicone-free	Hair only

BRAND	COMPANY	CATEGORY	POSITIONING	NATURAL GAP?
Deonatulle	Abe Shoten	Deodorant	Natural alum-stone	Closest competitor

APPENDIX C

Phased Market Entry Timeline

PHASE	TIMELINE	KEY ACTIVITIES
Phase 1	Months 1–12	Launch body wash + shampoo/conditioner on Amazon Japan & Rakuten. Build @cosme presence. Influencer seeding campaign. Initiate quasi-drug approval for deodorant.
Phase 2	Months 12–18	Expand to Loft, Plaza, @cosme STORE physical retail. Complete regulatory approval for deodorant. Launch Japan-exclusive scent lineup.
Phase 3	Month 18+	Deodorant launch in spray and roll-on formats. Expand to mass drugstore chains via P&G K.K. buyer relationships. Full marketing campaign around summer freshness.